

Session 20: Jacob and Laban Make a Covenant

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov and Lavan are on a path of mutual destruction, but, instead of another round of wronging each other, they choose to make peace through a covenant.
- A covenant is not the Eden ideal; it's how two parties fortify a relationship in a world where at least one party can't be fully trusted.
- The prophet Jeremiah gives us a glimpse of God's heart for a "new covenant," where the stipulations of a covenant are replaced by truly knowing God.

Yaaqov's Exile, From Beginning to End

43 **And Lavan replied and said to Yaaqov** ,
"The daughters are **my daughters** (הבנות בנתי) ,
and the sons are **my sons** (הבנים בני) ,
and the flocks are **my flocks** ,
and all that you see is **mine** .
But what can I do this day to these **my daughters** (לבנותי)
or to their **sons** (לבניהן) whom they have borne?
44 So now come, let us make a **covenant** , **I and you** ,
and let it be a **witness between me and you**."

45 **And Yaaqov** took **a stone** ,
and **he set it up** (וירימה) **as a pillar** .
46 And Yaaqov said to **his brothers** ,
"Gather **stones**."
And they took **stones** and made a **heap** ,
and they ate there by the **heap** .

47 And Lavan called it, "**Jegar** - **sahadutha** " [= Aram. "**Pile of Witness** "],
and Yaaqov called it, **Gal 'ed** " [= Heb. "**Heap of Witness** "].

48 **And Lavan said** ,
"This **heap** is a **witness between me and between you** this day."
Therefore it was named, "**Gal 'ed** ."
49 Also, "**Mizpah**," (מצפה)

for he said,

“May Yahweh **watch** (יִצֹף) **between me and between you**,
when each man hides from his companion.

50 If you oppress my daughters,
or if you take wives besides my daughters,
no man is with us,
see, Elohim is **witness** **between me and you.**”

51 **And Lavan said to Yaaqov ,**

“Behold this **heap** ,
and behold the **pillar which I have thrown** (יִרִיתִי) **between me and between you.**

52 This **heap** is a **witness** ,
and the **pillar** is a **witness** ,
that I will not pass over to you by this heap,
nor will you pass over to me by this heap, to do evil.

53 The Elohim of Abraham,
and the Elohim of Nahor,
the Elohim of their father,
may they judge **between us.**”

And Yaaqov **swore an oath** by the fear of his father Isaac.

54 And Yaaqov offered a sacrifice on the mountain,
and called **his brothers to eat** bread,
and they ate bread,
and they spent the night on the mountain.

32:1 And Lavan rose early in the morning,
and he kissed **his sons** and **his daughters**
and blessed them.
And Lavan departed and returned to his place.

Genesis 31:43-32:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

This scene, which concludes Yaaqov's exile in Lavan's house, has been designed to create a literary frame around the entire exile movement.

Genesis 28:10-22

God Appears to Yaaqov at Beth-el

- **28:12** God appears “in a dream” during the night
- **28:13** God appears as the “Elohim of Avraham and Yitskhaq, your fathers”
- “Look, I am with you”
- “I will return you to this land”
- **28:18** Yaaqov took a stone (אֶבֶן) and set up a standing-pillar (מַצְבֵּה)

- **28:20** Yaaqov vows a vow (נדר) to be loyal to Yahweh

Genesis 29:1-30:43

Yaaqov's Exile in Lavan's house

Genesis 31:1-32:1

- **31:1-16 God Appears to Yaaqov in Exile**
 - **31:10** God appears "in a dream"
 - "Return to the land of your fathers and your birth-family "
 - "and I will be with you"
 - "return to the land of your birth-family "
- **31:17-42 Lavan Chases after Yaaqov**
- **31:43-32:1 Yaaqov and Lavan Make a Covenant of Peace**
 - **31:45** Yaaqov took a stone (אבן) and set up a standing-pillar
 - **31:53** Yaaqov swears an oath (שבוע) to keep his promise to Lavan
 - **31:53** Yaaqov swears by "the Elohim of Nahor, Avraham, and Yitskhaq"

Genesis 28:10-32:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The motifs that appear in Yaaqov's Bethel dream (which begins the story of Yaaqov's exile) are split up and distributed among the first and the last units of the final scene of Yaaqov's exile. This type of design structure is intentional, as an effort to show how God's promises to Yaaqov at Bethel are being fulfilled, but in a surprising way.

- Yaaqov needs to fulfill his vow to Yahweh. In Genesis 31:1-16, he makes a commitment to do so.
- But Yaaqov has also gotten enmeshed in a complicated web of deception with Lavan. In order to fulfill his vow to Yahweh, he must also resolve his 20-year dispute with Lavan.
- And the way that Yaaqov makes peace with Lavan imitates the way he is going to make peace with *Elohim*, through a covenant of peace.

Brothers Make Peace Through a Covenant

This is the final scene of the Yaaqov and Lavan story. The entire story has created a deep tension between the two relatives. Yaaqov the deceiver has been counter-deceived by his uncle and taken advantage of in multiple ways. Yaaqov has returned the favor, and it's not at all clear how this escalating conflict is going to be resolved.

But in this scene, where things could have become violent, God intervenes on behalf of Yaaqov the deceiver and confronts Lavan the counter-deceiver. This taps into a whole network of earlier narrative patterns that culminate in peacemaking covenants.

Sibling Rivalry	Escalating Conflict	Violent De-creation / Re-creation Through Covenant
Cain and Abel	Lemek's 7x10 violence	Gen. 9:11-15 Flood of judgment / Covenant of peace This is the sign of the covenant which I am giving between me and between you and between every living creature that is with you, for everlasting generations. I have set my bow in the cloud, and it will be for a sign of a covenant between me and between the land ... and never again will the waters become a flood to ruin all flesh.
Sarah and Hagar	Sarah's hostility and exile of Hagar	Gen. 17:10-14 Judgment on Abraham's genitals / Covenant of peace This is my covenant that y'all will keep, between me and between y'all, and between your seed after you: circumcise for yourselves every male. And y'all will circumcise the flesh of your foreskin, and that will be as a sign of the covenant, between me and between y'all. ... And a foreskinned male that is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin, that person will be cut off from his people, he has violated my covenant.
Abraham and Abimelech	Dispute over a well	Gen. 21:27-32 Sacrificial animals / Covenant of peace And Avraham took sheep and oxen, and he gave to Avimelek, and the two of them cut a covenant. And Avraham set up seven female lambs of the flock alone, and Avimelek said to Avraham, "What are these seven female lambs that you have set up alone?" And he said, "Because the seven female lambs you will take from my hand, so that it will become a witness on my behalf, that I dug this well." For this reason, one calls that place Beer-Sheva (= "Well of Seven"), because there the two of them swore an oath and they cut a covenant at Beer-Sheva.
Yitskhaq and Abimelech	Disputes over many wells	Gen. 26:28-31 Covenant of peace "Let there now be an oath between us, between you and us, and let us make a covenant with you, that you will not do bad to us, just as we have not touched you and we have done to you nothing but good and we have sent you away in peace.

Sibling Rivalry and Covenant Peace. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Sibling Rivalry	Escalating Conflict	Violent De-creation / Re-creation Through Covenant
		You are now the one blessed by Yahweh.” And he made them a drink-feast, and they ate and drank . And they got up in the morning and they swore oaths, each with his brother , and Yitskhaq sent them away, and they went from him in peace.
Yaaqov and Lavan	Deceptions and counter-deceptions	Gen. 31:44, 52-54 Covenant of peace “So now, come, let us cut a covenant, I and you , and let it be a witness between me and between you .” ... “This heap is a witness, and the standing-stone is a witness, that I will not cross by this heap over to you, and you will not cross by this heap and this pillar to do bad. ...” So Yaaqov swore an oath by the fear of his father Yitskhaq. And Yaaqov sacrificed a sacrificial-offering on the mountain, and called his his brothers to eat bread, and they ate bread , and they stayed the night on the mountain.
<i>Sibling Rivalry and Covenant Peace. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>		

These developing patterns establish the importance of the covenant, a formal means of addressing conflict so that peace can be initiated.

In each of these cases, the conflict begins between rivals. Either the chosen or the non-chosen begins a cycle of conflict that escalates and is only brought to an end through the making of a covenant.

Yaaqov's Conflicts, Past and Future

The entire covenant-making scene with Lavan seems so unlikely that it creates hope for the reader. Perhaps Yaaqov's unresolved conflict with Esau can also be healed in a similar way to his rivalry with Lavan.

Reflection Question

What is the purpose of a covenant?



Module 5: Jacob's Return From Exile

SESSIONS 21-25

Jacob is finally ready to face the brother he betrayed. Will these two reconcile or will violence once again fill the land?